

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Habakkuk 1:1

The word message (or *oracle*) identifies the book as God's revelation through his prophet (cp. [Nah 1:1](#); [Mal 1:1](#)).

Habakkuk 1:2

call for help? . . . do not listen! The call/answer motif in Scripture often demonstrates the speaker's trust in God as a refuge or guide (see [Ps 102:1-2](#)) and indicates intimate communion between the believer and God ([Ps 145:18](#); [Isa 65:24](#)).

Habakkuk 1:2-4

To Habakkuk, God seemed indifferent to the evil permeating society in Judah ([1:3-4](#)) and unresponsive to his complaints about it ([1:2](#)).

Habakkuk 1:3

In Habakkuk's day, destruction and violence permeated Judean society (see Habakkuk Book Introduction, "Setting").

Habakkuk 1:4

Habakkuk expresses his concern about the injustice and unrighteousness he saw all around him (see [1:12-13](#); [2:4, 9](#)), even in the courts, where the law was no longer effective in maintaining justice.

Habakkuk 1:5

Look . . . look: Two different Hebrew verbs, both of which are here translated *look*, are translated as *see* and *watch* in [1:3](#). This forms a literary link between Habakkuk's questions in [1:3](#) and God's reply in [1:5-11](#).

Habakkuk 1:5-11

God's answer to Habakkuk's question is startling. God would send a violent people—the Babylonians—to deal with the violence in Judah. The Babylonian army, well-trained and battle-hardened, was an unstoppable force.

Habakkuk 1:7

do whatever they like: No relief from injustice would come from the Babylonians. They were a law unto themselves, which added to the prophet's perplexity at God's decision to use them to punish Judah.

Habakkuk 1:8

The vivid images of cheetahs, wolves, and eagles depict the speed, ferocity, and predatory nature of the Babylonian attacks against Judah (see [Jer 4:13](#); [48:40](#); [49:22](#)).

Habakkuk 1:9

The Babylonians indeed took many captives from Judah into exile between 605 and 586 BC (see [Dan 1:1-3](#)).

Habakkuk 1:10

The ancient battle tactic of building ramps of earth against the walls of cities under attack is widely attested in the ancient Near East (e.g., [2 Kgs 19:32](#); [Nah 2:1](#)).

Habakkuk 1:11

their own strength is their god: The Babylonians worshiped many false gods. The arrogant confidence they placed on their military strength amounted to one more idol in the mix.

Habakkuk 1:12

Despite his perplexity, Habakkuk did not renounce God. With the words my God, my Holy One, he reaffirmed his commitment to the Lord before asking serious questions about what God had revealed to him. • In light of God's character and covenant relationship with Israel, Habakkuk was certain that God would not wipe his people out. • to correct us: Cp. [Heb 12:5-11](#). • our Rock: A common image of God's faithfulness and strength (see [Deut 32:15](#); [1 Sam 2:2](#); [Ps 18:2](#); [1 Cor 10:4](#); [1 Pet 2:6-8](#)).

Habakkuk 1:12-2.1

Habakkuk found it difficult to harmonize God's answer ([1:5-11](#)) with what he understood about God's character. How could a holy and just God chastise Judah by using a people more unrighteous than they were?

Habakkuk 1:14-15

fish . . . hooks . . . nets: Habakkuk portrays the Babylonians as fishermen, drawing in conquered peoples.

Habakkuk 1:16

See study note on 1:11; cp. [1 Jn 5:21](#).

Habakkuk 2:1

I will . . . stand at my guardpost: Like a sentinel on duty (see also [2 Sam 18:24-28](#); [2 Kgs 9:17-20](#); [Ezek 33:2-6](#)), Habakkuk waited expectantly to see how God would answer his complaint, even if that meant being reproved by the Lord.

Habakkuk 2:2

God instructs the prophet to write the message (literally *vision*) plainly so that it will be understood, preserved, and shared with others.

Habakkuk 2:2-5

Habakkuk's mission was to make it clear to people that even if God's justice seems slow in coming, it will come.

Habakkuk 2:2-20

God responds to Habakkuk's second complaint ([1:12-2:1](#)) without explaining why he chose to use the Babylonians. Rather, he assures Habakkuk that all violence and injustice will be punished.

Habakkuk 2:3

will surely take place: In a set future time known only to the Lord, he will intervene in earth's history and bring it to a proper culmination, vindicating the righteous and judging the wicked. God's people must wait patiently, knowing that the divine plan is on schedule (see [Heb 10:35-38](#)).

Habakkuk 2:4

God is aware of the self-centeredness of the proud. Their crooked lives demonstrate their unrighteousness; they refuse God's instruction and gratify their own desires ([Prov 12:15](#); [21:8](#), [29](#); [29:27](#)). In contrast, the righteous enjoy proper judicial standing before God. They make God's righteous standards their own and reproduce them in their lives. • faithfulness: Hebrew 'emunah. In Genesis, the same Hebrew root ('mn) describes Abram's trust in God ([Gen 15:6](#)). God transforms the hearts of those who trust him so they can faithfully follow God's holy standards. See also [Rom 1:16-17](#); [Gal 3:11](#); [Heb 10:37-39](#).

Habakkuk 2:6-8

In the first of Habakkuk's taunt songs, he condemns the Babylonians for despoiling the nations. • thieves . . . extortion: The imagery compares the Babylonians to creditors whose oppressive measures cause their debtors to rise up against them. Greed can easily mar an individual's or nation's spiritual fiber ([Luke 12:15](#); [Eph 5:3](#)).

Habakkuk 2:6–20

Five taunt songs ([2:6–8](#), [9–11](#), [12–14](#), [15–17](#), [18–20](#)) portray God's future judgment of the Babylonians (and others who, like the Babylonians, indulge in violence and injustice). God allows them to seal their own doom. Those who suffer will be able to repeat these taunts when the wicked come to judgment (see [1:14–17](#)). Each taunt contains a pronouncement of sorrow, a judgment, and the reason for God's judgment.

Habakkuk 2:9–11

In the second taunt song, the Babylonians are condemned for their dishonest dealings. Since the Babylonians obtained the means to build big houses through deceit and dishonesty, they forfeited their lives.

Habakkuk 2:12–14

In the third taunt song, the Babylonians are condemned for the murder and corruption of human life and society that brought wealth to build their cities. God would make their apparent gain prove to be a total loss. • earth will be filled: The antithesis of violence and ill-gotten wealth is the awareness of the glory of the Lord, which God promises to make as pervasive as water in the ocean ([Isa 11:9](#)).

Habakkuk 2:15–17

In the fourth taunt song, the Babylonians are condemned for their disgraceful acts against people, animals, and the environment. They are like a man who seems to be hospitable, but after getting his neighbors drunk, strips them of everything. However, the Babylonians will be disgraced after drinking from the cup of the Lord's judgment (see [Jer 25:15–17](#); cp. [John 18:11](#)).

Habakkuk 2:18–20

In the fifth taunt song, the Babylonians are condemned for their devotion to idolatry. Whether idols are carved or cast by the hand of man, they can neither save nor teach their worshipers ([Isa](#)

[42:17](#)). Only the Lord truly deserves our worship ([Hab 2:20](#); [Exod 20:2–6](#); cp. [Eccl 5:1–2](#)).

Habakkuk 2:20

The taunt songs close with a declaration: The one who is sovereign over all nations is not a Babylonian idol ([2:18–20](#)) but the Holy God. Unlike the lifeless Babylonian idols, the living God indwells his holy Temple. God's presence fills his heavenly sanctuary ([Isa 6:1–5](#))—and in Habakkuk's time, it filled the Temple in Jerusalem ([1 Kgs 8:10–11](#)). God controls all the earth and expects people to worship him in humble submission ([Ps 63:1–4](#); [Jer 10:1–10](#); [Mic 7:16](#); [Zech 2:13](#)).

Habakkuk 3:1–19

Habakkuk's prophecy concludes with a psalm-like prayer.

Habakkuk 3:2

Habakkuk stands in awe before the Sovereign One who sits enthroned in his holy Temple ([2:20](#)). • In light of God's message of Judah's coming chastisement, Habakkuk prays that God, who has miraculously intervened on Israel's behalf in the past, will once again make known his work of redemption (see also [Ps 77](#)).

Habakkuk 3:3

Edom (Hebrew *Teman*): Teman was one of Edom's chief cities (see also [Job 2:11](#); [Jer 49:7](#)); the term could refer to the entire region of Edom where the city was located (cp. [Obad 1:9](#)). Habakkuk's use of the term in conjunction with Mount Paran suggests that he had the broader region in mind. • Holy One is a prominent title for God, as holiness is his defining characteristic ([Hab 1:12](#); see also [Exod 15:11](#); [2 Kgs 19:22](#); [Ps 77:13](#); [Isa 6:3](#)). • Mount Paran: The region of Paran included the mountain range west and south of Edom and northeast of Mount Sinai, as well as a broad desert area in the Sinai Peninsula.

Habakkuk 3:3–15

The prophet praises God's power to save. These two praise stanzas ([3:3–7](#) and [3:8–15](#)) are a poetic reflection upon Israel's exodus experience. Although Habakkuk's focus is upon God's redemption of his people, his imagery occasionally reflects ideas found in ancient Near Eastern tales concerning the gods (e.g., pestilence and plague, [3:5](#); river and sea, [3:8](#); sun and moon, [3:11](#)). This imagery reminds Habakkuk's original readers that the Lord alone is the one true God who is sovereign over all these things.

Habakkuk 3:4

brilliant as the sunrise: The Lord, who once appeared on Mount Sinai and filled the southern land with his glory, fills the heavens with his splendor.

Habakkuk 3:5

Habakkuk personifies pestilence (see [Deut 32:24](#)) and plague (see [Exod 7:12](#); [Amos 4:10](#)) as soldiers in God's army, fulfilling his purposes.

Habakkuk 3:5–6

God is the divine warrior who intervenes on behalf of his own (see [3:8–15](#); see also [Isa 63:1–6](#)).

Habakkuk 3:7

Midian occupied the southern part of the region just east of the Jordan (see [Gen 36:35](#)); the nation was trembling in terror at the earth-shaking power of God's presence ([Hab 3:6](#)).

Habakkuk 3:8

struck the rivers . . . parted the sea: See [Exod 7:19–20](#); [14:15–31](#). • chariots of salvation: An ironic echo of the Egyptian chariots, which pursued the Israelites when God led them to escape through the Red Sea ([Exod 14:9](#)).

Habakkuk 3:8–15

The Lord is a divine warrior for his people, moving in redemptive power on their behalf. The motif of God as divine warrior spans both Old Testament and New Testament: It is seen in Israel's exodus from Egypt, their movement to Mount Sinai ([Exod 15:1–18](#)), their approach to the Promised Land from the south, and their triumphs in the early conquest period (e.g., [Judg 5:4–5](#); [Pss 18:8–16](#); [77:16–20](#); a key New Testament example is [Rev 19:11–21](#)).

Habakkuk 3:9–11

Only God controls the forces of the natural world.

Habakkuk 3:10

waters: See study note on 3:8; see also [Exod 15:1–18](#).

Habakkuk 3:11

sun and moon: See [Josh 10:12–13](#).

Habakkuk 3:15

sea . . . waters: The section ends as it began ([3:8](#)).

Habakkuk 3:16

Although the full realization of God's mighty power sapped Habakkuk's strength to the point that he trembled, he would wait quietly (see [2:3](#)) for God's judgment to descend.

Habakkuk 3:17–19

After recounting God's mighty acts of redemption ([3:2–15](#)), and pausing to consider them ([3:16](#)), Habakkuk now reaffirms his trust in God as he closes his prayer. • Even though . . . yet I will rejoice: Even if God never pours out material blessing on his people again, he is still worthy of all the trust and praise they can give. Come what may, the prophet could rejoice, knowing that the Lord is not

only Israel's Redeemer, but also the source of his own salvation.

Habakkuk 3:19

Habakkuk owed whatever strength he had to the Sovereign Lord, his Savior ([3:18](#)). Habakkuk compared his spiritual climb to a deer swiftly ascending to the mountaintops and gracefully gliding over them (cp. [Ps 18:32-33](#)).